



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Literature



Your notes

Stories of Ourselves Volume 2

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Stories of Ourselves Volume 2

In **Paper 1, Section B (Prose)**, you'll answer **one question on one story** from this selection. You'll choose between:

- A **passage-based question** (analyse how the writer creates effects in a printed extract)
- An **essay-style question** (explore a theme, character, or idea across the whole story)

You'll need to revise **all** the selected short stories because examiners can ask questions of any of the following ten short stories from the Stories of Ourselves anthology. Follow the links for dedicated revision notes on each of the stories:

Story No.	Story title	Author	Date
3	Nick	Christina Rossetti	1850
14	The Woman's Rose	Olive Schreiner	1899
26	The Black Ball	Ralph Ellison	1937
30	The Gold Watch	Mulk Raj Anand	1959
35	When It Happens	Margaret Atwood	1977
37	The Man Who Walked on the Moon	J.G. Ballard	1985
38	A Walk to the Jetty	Jamaica Kincaid	1985
40	Showing the Flag	Jane Gardam	1989
47	Haywards Heath	Aminatta Forna	2010
49	Fluke	Romesh Gunsekera	2014

Summaries of each short story

Nick by Christina Rossetti

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features



Your notes

A man's envious wishes lead to transformations (sparrows, dog, stick, fire, old man) until he learns to be humble.	Envy, punishment and redemption, morality	Fairy-tale allegory, omniscient narrator with direct address, symbolism of transformations
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The Woman's Rose by Olive Schreiner

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
A young woman recalls rivalry with another girl in a male-dominated settlement, ending in rare solidarity symbolised by a rose.	Patriarchy, rivalry versus sisterhood, solidarity, memory	Allegory, symbolism (rose, light and dark), reflective flashback structure

The Black Ball by Ralph Ellison

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
John, a Black janitor, reflects on his son's future, his union struggles, and the metaphorical "black ball" of exclusion.	Racism, injustice, fatherhood, hope for change	First-person narration, symbolism ("black ball"), irony, colour imagery

The Gold Watch by Mulk Raj Anand

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Sharma is forced to retire after 20 years of service, receiving only a gold watch as a hollow token of colonial "reward".	Colonial exploitation, ageism, futility of loyalty, disillusionment	Irony, symbolism (watch, Buick versus train), satirical tone, omniscient narration

When It Happens by Margaret Atwood

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Farm wife Mrs Burridge obsessively prepares for a vague disaster, torn between practicality and paranoia.	Fear, isolation, utopia versus dystopia, history and memory	Shifts in tense, symbolism (gun, fortress, food), cyclical ending

The Man Who Walked on the Moon by J.G. Ballard



Your notes

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
A drifter befriends Scranton, who claims to be an astronaut, only to inherit his delusional identity after his death.	Identity, delusion versus reality, alienation, freedom	Unreliable first-person narrator, cyclical structure, irony, astronaut imagery as metaphor

A Walk to the Jetty by Jamaica Kincaid

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Annie leaves Antigua for England, reflecting critically on family, colonial upbringing, and her own independence.	Adolescence, colonial identity, rebellion, migration	First-person subjective narration, irony, symbolism (jetty, sea)

Showing the Flag by Jane Gardam

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Young Philip travels alone to France, clinging to a Union Jack as a symbol of identity and security.	Family separation, cultural identity, childhood anxiety, maternal guilt	Irony, symbolism (flag, suitcase, food), dialogue shaping misunderstanding

Haywards Heath by Aminatta Forna

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Attila visits his old love Rosie in an English care home, only to find her lost to dementia.	Memory, lost romance, past versus present, diaspora identity	Omniscient narration, symbolism (Jaguar car, sweets), nostalgic imagery, pathos

Fluke by Romesh Gunsekera

One-sentence plot summary	Key themes and ideas	Key language features
Taxi driver Vasantha contrasts his modest business and peace of mind with a businessman's obsession with status and technology.	Tradition versus modernity, illusion versus reality, nature versus artifice	First-person monologue, humour, symbolism (sea, phone, "good chi"), irony



Your notes

Tips for success

- Read the question carefully and highlight the **key words**
- Use **precise quotations** (short phrases or single words) to support points
- Focus on the **writer's choices** of language, structure, and form
- Avoid just retelling the story — always link back to the question
- Write a short plan, keep responses structured, and end with a **personal response** to the text



Nick analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Nick by Christina Rossetti contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Nick

Christina Rossetti's short story Nick was written in 1853, and is part of a collection called Commonplace and Other Stories. The cautionary tale follows the dissatisfied [protagonist](#), Nick, who lives in a fairytale village.

Nick has a comfortable life. He is self-sufficient, and has a thriving farm. But he is envious of all the things his neighbours have. Despite his own material wealth, Nick is jealous and wishes bad luck and harm on his neighbours.

To teach him a lesson, a magical "little rosy woman" the size of a "butterfly" appears to Nick. She tells him he has the power to wish to be anything he likes for an hour at a time. So follows a series of Nick's poorly-intended wishes. First of all, he wishes to become a flock of sparrows to attack his neighbour's cherries. When he is shot down and attacked by a cat, he wishes to be a dog. In the form of a dog he attacks the cat, which leads the townspeople to chase him. To save himself, Nick turns himself into a stick, but is taken home by one of the villagers, where he is thrown into their fire.

A furious Nick then decides to transform himself in the fire itself, so he can burn the villager's house down in revenge. As he does so, he is doused with water and becomes a small flame. At this point, an exhausted Nick finally realises his choices have been destructive, and have caused nothing but pain.

Eager to make a good wish, he wishes to be a rich old man so he can help the villagers, but, that very night, robbers break in and steal his possessions and plan to murder him. As he lies in his own grave, he wishes to be himself once more, and manages to escape.

Back home, a humbler man, Nick seeks redemption by fixing all the damage he has done, and never wishes for anything else again.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. This will help you to form a structural analysis, which means you will be considering how themes and characters develop (or not) through the story.



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Nick

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Christina Rossetti's Nick.

What are the key themes in Nick?

Theme	Analysis
Envy	▪ Rossetti's protagonist Nick is described as "poor" despite an abundant life: ▪ This conveys the idea of envy as a state of poverty ▪ It encourages the reader to challenge traditional ideas of wealth and consider the real meaning of contentment ▪ Nick's desires for more than he already has, and his jealousy of what others have, manifest in self-pity: ▪ Rossetti makes it clear that Nick's home is the "prettiest and snuggest in all the place" ▪ Yet he "would sit grumbling and bemoaning himself as if every other man's riches were his poverty" ▪ Rossetti delivers messages about wanting more through the symbolic idea of "wishes": ▪ Nick's selfish wishes presents envy as a destructive force
Redemption	▪ Rossetti's story progresses through a series of ironic consequences to Nick's poor choices: ▪ For instance, he changes into a stick to escape the angry villagers, only to be thrown onto a fire ▪ Nick's transformations are symbolic in that they constitute painful lessons: ▪ As a bird he is attacked by a cat: he "chirped in desperation" ▪ As a fire, he is "surrounded by a wall of wet ashes" where he "sat and smouldered"



Your notes

- Rossetti alludes to self-sacrifice as a means to salvation:
 - After he wishes to be a stick, Nick is thrown on the villager's fire and "crackled and blazed away cheerfully"
 - Nick must become humble, grateful, and pay back his victims in order to find a sense of peace
- The story suggests redemption is a "deliverance":
 - Nick's "reflection" and silent "pondering" help him see his mistakes
 - Nick's change is signalled dramatically: "His wish suddenly found vent in a prolonged unearthly yell"
 - Rossetti refers to Nick as "our hero"

Writer's Methods in Nick

How does Rossetti present her ideas and perspectives?

Rossetti uses natural [imagery](#) and a traditional [narrative](#) structure to create an [allegory](#).

Technique	Analysis
Symbolism	■ Rossetti's story is an allegory that delivers messages about karma or retribution: ■ Nick's choices are symbolised by wishes ■ The fire that Nick turns into is presented as a purifying element once he becomes "one blue flame" and reflects on his actions ■ The idea of wealth is represented with simple imagery, like "green verandah and flower-garden" and the alliterative "wholesome herbs" ■ The fairy represents a supernatural being who appears to teach a human being a lesson: ■ This character is typical in fairytales, like Beauty and the Beast, and didactic prose like Charles Dickens' A Christmas Carol ■ Often, such supernatural guardians of morality are described as small, yet fierce ■ Rossetti's "rosy" fairy is as small as a "butterfly", but has a "menacing attitude" and looks at Nick "scornfully"
Omniscient narrator	■ The story begins in typical fairy-tale style:



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- “There dwelt in a small village, not a thousand miles from Fairyland”
- Rossetti’s **third-person omniscient narrator** is conversational:
 - “When I call him poor, you must not suppose he was a homeless wanderer”
- The story progresses through a linear **narrative** to show Nick’s development as a character as a result of events
- Typical for a fairytale, Rossetti characterises her **protagonist** as a hero despite his flaws:
 - “Up jumped our hero”
 - Rossetti **ironically** calls Nick “our hero”, who only becomes sympathetic after his redemption
- Interestingly, Rossetti’s final line alludes to fairytale villains that are often never heard of more:
 - Despite his redemption, the story ends “Nick was never again heard to utter a wish”



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners report that the best answers to the prose question focus on the authors’ choices of language and literary methods, and the effects these might have on a reader. You will be rewarded for a thoughtful argument that is closely supported by detailed references to the text, and analysis of the writer’s choices.

For example, in the short story Nick, Christina Rossetti explores ideas about envy by using the literary form of a magical fairy-tale. This helps her present universal, timeless ideas about morality in a light-hearted, less **didactic** way.

Key quotations in Nick

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. Remember, though, that summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referencing plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Christina Rossetti’s Nick, arranged by the following themes:

- Envy
- Redemption

Envy

In Christina Rossetti's story Nick, the **protagonist** is a fortunate and successful man, but he looks upon his neighbours' possessions with jealousy, and thinks that if they had less he would have more.



Your notes



"It was in vain that his apples were the largest for miles around" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator says that even though Nick's apples were the best in the whole village and beyond, it was for nothing as Nick did not appreciate them

Analysis

- This line is the first of two that lists Nick's successes
- The **narrator** suggests the idea of waste in the phrase "It was in vain", implying he might as well not have had anything at all
- Rossetti shows that abundance cannot bring happiness if jealousy exists:
 - Despite Nick having the best apples, and "lambs" that were "fat and thriving", he cannot enjoy them



"He would sit grumbling and bemoaning himself as if every other man's riches were his poverty" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator describes how Nick becomes unhappy and resentful because he is jealous of others' possessions

Analysis

- Rossetti uses present tense verbs "grumbling and bemoaning" to present Nick as constantly miserable as a result of his envy
- Rossetti suggests envy leads to a kind of poverty:
 - She implies that his perception of being less well off than his neighbours means he sees himself as poorer than them
- Rossetti presents envy as socially destructive, as well as personally damaging:
 - His resentment at others' success leads to his isolation
 - He has no "family to labour for or friend to assist"



“It was provocation enough to be burned; but to contribute by his misfortune to the well-being of his tormentors was still more aggravating” — Narrator



Your notes

Meaning and context

- Even as Nick (in the form of a stick in the villager’s fire) burns, he is envious that his “tormentors” are enjoying the warmth he creates
- This is even more annoying than being burned

Analysis

- Rossetti shows how envy can lead one to be spiteful even at one’s own expense
- That Nick is more annoyed by the “well-being” of the villagers than the fact he is being burned is humorous
- Rossetti suggests envy is irrational and foolish

Redemption



“Then she gave him a slap in the face, which made his cheek tingle as if a bee had stung him” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The “little rosy woman” (a fairy) tells Nick that he “shall straightway become everything” he wishes, and then slaps him for being a “churl” (a rude person)
- The “slap” makes his “cheek” sting

Analysis

- Rossetti uses a [simile](#) to compare the “slap” to a bee sting
- This connotes to a punishment, or a shock that aims to awaken Nick
- Rossetti implies that redemption is a painful process
- Natural **imagery** (a “bee”) contributes to the story’s simplistic, fairy-tale style



“In this wish he burned out” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- As Nick smoulders as “one blue flame”, he reflects on his actions
- He decides that his next wish should be one that benefits him but does not harm his neighbours
- As he wishes to become a “rich old man”, he burns out

Analysis

- Rossetti perhaps uses Nick’s transformation into fire as symbolic:
 - Fire is often used as a symbol either of ultimate punishment or purification
- Indeed, Nick finally learns an important lesson when he is reduced to a “blue flame”:
 - His own success should not be at the expense of others



“And now entertained only one wish — that he were himself again” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Finally, Nick makes his last wish, to transform back into “himself”

Analysis

- Rossetti’s presentation of the theme of redemption is delivered via the painful and humiliating consequences of Nick’s badly intended wishes
- By the end of the story, Rossetti implies that Nick’s sins, his ungratefulness and his spiteful jealousy, are redeemed through humility
- That Nick wishes to be “himself again” culminates his cyclical journey of self-development

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Your notes



The Woman's Rose analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

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The following guide to The Woman's Rose by Olive Schreiner contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of The Woman's Rose

Olive Schreiner was a South African writer, born in 1855. Her short story, The Woman's Rose, published in 1891, focuses on female relationships, particularly within a male-dominated society.

It opens with the **first-person** narrator describing a wooden box. The box contains precious keepsakes, which include a faded white rose. The rose reminds her of a significant moment in her past, which the narrator goes on to relate.

As a teenage girl, she visited a small town. The settlement was largely dominated by men, and there was only one other woman of similar age to the narrator living there. The woman was beautiful and attracted the men's attention. However, when the narrator arrived, the men's affections and attention suddenly moved away from the woman and towards her. She explains that this placed a barrier between the two women. Instead of becoming friends and allies, they did not speak to each other. In fact, the men's behaviour created a sense of rivalry between them.

The night before she left the town, a party was held. It was at this party she and the woman finally spoke to each other. The woman placed a rare white rose (taken from her own blonde hair) in her black hair, saying that flowers look better in darker hair.

Although she never saw the woman again, the narrator explains that whenever she feels a sense of despair, she looks at the rose and remembers their friendship, and this brings her strength and renews her hope.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. This will help

you to form a structural analysis, which means you will be considering how themes and characters develop (or not) through the story.



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in The Woman's Rose

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Olive Schreiner's *The Woman's Rose*.

What are the key themes in *The Woman's Rose*?

Theme	Analysis
Gender	- Schreiner raises ideas about patriarchal attitudes by setting her story in a town that "consisted mainly of men": - The narrator says that the young men in the town "worshipped" the woman with "light" hair, and then later, her - The story describes a young teenage girl who quickly decides that the men around her make superficial romantic gestures: - They are "simply a fashion, which one man had set and the rest followed unreasoningly" - She says the men always look for someone "new" - Schreiner illustrates how the men's comparison of the women's beauty creates a sense of rivalry: - The narrator compares her looks to the woman with "dreamy blue eyes" and says the woman is "prettier" - The alliance between her and the woman, symbolised by the gift of a rose, stems from their shared experiences with men: - By the end, the women form a bond by complementing each other on their appearance, and rejecting the men - The narrator describes how she threw away the flowers given to her by a man, but kept the rose
Hope	- Schreiner raises the theme of hope through a symbolic "rose": - The "scent of that dead rose, withered for twelve years" brings back a significant memory to the narrator - Schreiner suggests that sisterhood brings strength: - When she finds the female experience a struggle, the rose reminds her that "there will be spring"

- She compares looking at the rose to when birds “see above the snow two tiny, quivering green leaves”
- This implies female friendship is fragile, but offers hope



Your notes

Writer's methods in The Woman's Rose

How does Schreiner present her ideas and perspectives?

Schreiner's story The Woman's Rose is an [allegory](#) about male and female relationships and the idea of female solidarity.

Technique	Analysis
Symbolism	▪ Schreiner's story uses a “withered” rose (a keepsake) to symbolise female friendship and to suggest it is rare and precious ▪ The rose is described as special: ▪ On the rose bush there was only “one bud. It was white” ▪ The short sentence brings attention to the symbolic colour, alluding to the friendship as a pure, genuine connection ▪ Schreiner uses imagery connoting to light to describe the memory of the woman with “bright hair glittering in the candle-light”: ▪ The woman who gives the rose to the narrator is dressed in “pure white, with her great white arms and shoulders showing” ▪ Schreiner alludes to the magical qualities of the rose and the woman who gives it to her ▪ The story ends connecting the rose with the season of spring: ▪ “The scent of that small withered thing comes back:—spring cannot fail us” ▪ While the rose represents sisterhood, “spring” alludes to hope
Flashback	▪ Schreiner's first-person narrator begins the story in the present tense: ▪ “I have an old, brown carved box” ▪ This gives the intimate monologue a sense of immediacy ▪ The significance of memory is introduced as a theme in the short sentence “I have in it a rose” ▪ The return to a moment when the narrator was fifteen years old allows Schreiner to discuss gender dynamics through the eyes of an innocent girl:

- The **flashback** begins “It is many years ago now; I was a girl of fifteen”
- This gives the **allegory** a sense of **poignant** naivete



Your notes



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners have said that the best answers to the prose question on the CIE Literature in English Paper 1, focus on the authors' choices of language and literary methods, and the effects these might have on a reader.

You will be rewarded for a thoughtful argument that is closely supported by detailed references to the text, and analysis of the writer's choices. For instance, in Olive Schreiner's short story *The Woman's Rose*, a rose symbolises female solidarity: the support and sense of connection that can be found in female relationships.

Key quotations in *The Woman's Rose*

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. Remember, though, summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referencing plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Olive Schreiner's *The Woman's Rose*, arranged by the following themes:

- Gender
- Hope

Gender

Schreiner's story criticises **fickle** and **superficial** attitudes to female beauty through her presentation of a teenage girl in a male-dominated world. At the same time, the story depicts how two women's shared experiences of male rivalry bring them together.



“When my eye is dim, and my heart grows faint, and my faith in woman flickers, and her present is an agony to me, and her future a despair, the scent of that dead rose, withered for twelve years, comes back to me” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The adult narrator says that they are sometimes confused and weakened



- When their belief in women wavers (“flickers”), or when life is painful and the future desperate, the smell of a “dead rose” helps them find strength
- Even though the rose is “withered” and dead, the smell comes back, and this reminds them of a significant moment 12 years before

Analysis

- Schreiner uses **polysyndeton** to emphasise the many times the narrator feels distressed by the female experience:
 - Sensory **imagery** contrasts the “scent” of a rose with the idea of death
 - This dramatic line presents heightened emotions



“But I was vital, and I was new, and she was old — they all forsook her and followed me” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator remembers how the men shifted their attentions from the woman with the “light” hair to her when she arrived in the new town
- She says it was because she was someone fresh whom they had never seen
- She says they “forsook” (abandoned) the woman and “followed” her instead

Analysis

- Through the frank and intimate **monologue** of a teenage girl, Schreiner conveys men as impulsive and shallow when it comes to their relationships with women:
 - The narrator, aged 15, calls the 17-year-old “old”, which highlights how quickly women were judged by appearance and novelty, while also reflecting her naive, adolescent perspective
- The word “old”, though, has been explicitly used to contrast “new”, suggesting the men got bored of the woman and she has now lost her value:
 - In contrast, the narrator is a novelty to them



“I despised them” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator remembers how the male rivalry over the women, and their superficial affection towards her, made her hate them

Analysis

- Schreiner's story expresses the thoughts and feelings of an honest, young girl
- The short sentence emphasises the extreme reaction to the men's actions
- This presents a harsh criticism of male and female relationships



Your notes

Hope



"Other women also have such boxes where they keep such trifles, but no one has my rose" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Looking in a special wooden box of keepsakes, the narrator says that lots of women have a place to keep memorable objects
- She says, though, that her rose is special, and unique to her

Analysis

- Schreiner begins her story by indicating the significance of the rose
- This creates suspense, and highlights the importance of the rose's story



"She was dressed in pure white, with her great white arms and shoulders showing, and her bright hair glittering in the candle-light, and the white rose fastened at her breast" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator describes the woman she meets at her going-away party
- The woman was in "white", wore a "white rose", and had pale skin
- Her hair was shining in the soft light

Analysis

- Schreiner's **imagery** alludes to purity and light to present the woman as innocent and angelic, which signifies the woman's influence
- Her "white" dress and "bright hair" contrasts with the narrator who is described with dark hair and in an "old black dress"
- This highlights the initial disconnect between the women and shows them as rivals in oppositional positions





“When my faith in woman grows dim, and it seems that for want of love and magnanimity she can play no part in any future heaven; then the scent of that small withered thing comes back:—spring cannot fail us” — Narrator



Your notes

Meaning and context

- The narrator repeats similar ideas at the beginning and end of her story
- As she comes to the end of her memory, back in present day, she concludes that the rose, a “small, withered thing” has great power:
 - At times, when she loses faith, feels no love and generosity of spirit, and sees no future in “heaven”, she remembers the rose
- The rose reminds her that there is always spring after winter, and, thus, hope

Analysis

- Schreiner’s story is cyclical in nature:
 - It begins and ends with the narrator looking at the dead rose the woman gave her when she was a teenager
 - The story shows the timeless power of memory by evoking the smell of a “withered” rose
- The symbolism of “spring” is used throughout the story to represent hope and rebirth:
 - Schreiner draws connections between the reliability of the changing seasons and the ever-lasting power of the rose to represent the female bond

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



The Black Ball analysis

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The following guide to The Black Ball by Ralph Ellison contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of The Black Ball

American author Ralph Ellison wrote the short story in 1937, and it was first published in 1967 in *Flying Home and Other Stories*. It is a semi-autobiographical **first-person** account of a Black father's challenging day, working and raising his son alone in a racially-segregated America.

John works as a janitor for a luxury apartment block. This particular morning, he rushes back from work to get breakfast for his young son. The boy tells his father that one of the white children called him "black". John says that he is "brown", and, most importantly, American.

Back at work, while polishing brass door knobs, John thinks about his rude and petty boss, Mr Berry. He is approached by a man with "red" skin typical of the "deep South". John is suspicious, but the man encourages John to join his **union**. To convince him of his good intentions, he reveals his scarred hands, and describes how a **white supremacist** mob set fire to him for supporting a wrongly-accused Black man, and **lynched** his friend. The union organiser gives John a card with the details of the meeting, and leaves.

At lunchtime, John warns his son not to play with his football at the front of the building because that is where the white boys play, but while he is asleep a white boy takes the ball from his son and throws it at Mr Berry's window. Mr Berry confronts John and warns him that if the ball is thrown again, he will be "behind the black ball" (a threat to fire him, but a reference to **disenfranchisement**).

Later, when John goes to water the lawn, he reflects on his son's future, and that he, too, will be blackballed, or excluded. Remembering the union man's scarred hands, he looks for the card with the details of the union meeting and wonders if there is any other colour than "white" on his son's ball.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. This will help you to form a structural analysis, which means you will be considering how themes and characters develop (or not) through the story.



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in The Black Ball

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Ralph Ellison's *The Black Ball*.

What are the key themes in The Black Ball?

Theme	Analysis
Discrimination	▪ The story describes the everyday life of a Black father in 20th-century America: ▪ Through the first-person perspective, Ellison illustrates the wariness and doubt John feels all day ▪ The story relates John's cynical thoughts while he works as a janitor in an expensive apartment block where white people live: ▪ He is suspicious of the white men around him, fearing their power to take his job or "put one over on" him ▪ His concerns are proven reasonable when a white boy escapes punishment and John's son is blamed
Hope	▪ The story's intimate depiction of John's relationship with his innocent son creates a poignant tone: ▪ His son expresses his wish to "drive a truck" when he's older ▪ The story's inciting incident comes in the form of a white union organiser who offers John a way to improve his conditions: ▪ Initially, John's resignation to his plight (and to his son's similarly hopeless future) shows how injustice has led to passivity ▪ The climax of the story initiates John's desire for change: ▪ He is threatened and his son is wrongly blamed ▪ By the end, John entertains the possibility of hope for his son's future, though his tone remains cautious and uncertain

Writer's methods in The Black Ball

How does Ellison present his ideas and perspectives?



Your notes

Ralph Ellison illustrates the results of **racial segregation** in early 20th-century America through his depiction of a struggling and fearful working father, and a tortured white **civil rights** supporter. The story advocates for solidarity and action to ensure a fairer future.

Technique	Analysis
Symbolism	▪ The story uses colour to symbolise race: ▪ John's son asks if he is "black", and John replies that he is "brown" ▪ In contrast, the man from the union is described with "red" skin, typical of the "deep South" ▪ In descriptions of the man's burned hands Ellison draws connections between fire and the "hell" of racial violence ▪ Ellison uses juxtaposition to symbolise the idea of discrimination: ▪ The symbolic "black ball" represents Black Americans' disenfranchisement, while John's white ball represents privilege ▪ John hopes that there will be "a color other than white on the old ball" in the future ▪ Ellison represents the idea of unionisation and change by referring to "trucks", and his son's desire to one day become a truck driver: ▪ In contrast, John's work polishing "brass" panels and doorknobs symbolises the idea of exploitation, and alludes to slavery
First-person narrative	▪ A first-person narrator, John, begins the story with present tense continuous verbs: ▪ This emphasises his busy day and his manual work ▪ He is "mopping", "sweeping", "dusting", and "emptying" ▪ John's intimate monologue shows his distrust, which reveals his deeply-ingrained sense of injustice: ▪ He describes his boss as a villain, "gazing into the brass like the wicked queen into her looking glass" ▪ His dialogue with his son gives the story a poignant innocence: ▪ "You always kid, don't you, Daddy?"





Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward essay responses that recognise and appreciate ways in which writers use language, structure and form to create and shape meanings and effects. This means you should write about the way language choices, settings, and characterisations raise ideas or present the writer's attitudes.

For instance, in the short story *The Black Ball*, Ralph Ellison illustrates how a father's concerns for his son's future initiate and motivate change.



Your notes

Key quotations in *The Black Ball*

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. Remember, though, summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referencing plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Ralph Ellison's *The Black Ball*, arranged by the following themes:

- **Discrimination**
- **Hope**

▪

Discrimination

Ellison's story highlights the entrenched racism existing in America in the early 20th century through his depiction of an isolated and anxious Black janitor and his innocent son.



"Some people think so. But American is better than both, son" — John

Meaning and context

- When John's son says that "brown" is better than "white", John quips that some people think being "white" is better
- He adds that being "American" is more important than the colour of one's skin

Analysis

- Ellison raises ideas about discrimination in 20th-century America, suggesting that being a citizen of America should not depend on race
- Ellison presents his [protagonist](#) as patriotic despite injustices to which he is subjected





“A smile couldn’t change things between my kind and his” — John



Your notes

Meaning and context

- When the union man smiles at him, John is distrustful
- He thinks the man’s polite smile will not change racist attitudes or past **oppression**

Analysis

- Through John’s **monologue**, Ellison presents cultural barriers between two strangers — “my kind and his”:
 - Regardless of behaviour now, bitterness and doubt remains
- Ellison may be alluding to slavery, as well as the **Jim Crow** laws, under which Ellison lived



“What ever caused you to give a damn about a Negro anyway? Why should you try to organize Negroes?” — John

Meaning and context

- John questions the union man as he finds his offer of help suspicious
- He says that white men have never seen reason to help before, and asks why is he trying to do so now, suggesting it is not his place to “organise” Black men

Analysis

- Ellison illustrates how John’s fear and anxiety manifests in a **cynical** attitude
- His interrogative tone presents him as frustrated and bitter at the complicity of those who allowed **racial segregation** and **oppression** to occur
- The italicised and repeated word “you” addresses all white men, not just the union man

Hope



“Those hands were on my brain, and I couldn’t forget that fellow” — John

Meaning and context

- John thinks about the union man when he goes home
- He remembers his scarred hands, and how he got them

Analysis

- Ellison uses a [metaphor](#) to convey John's distracted thoughts about the union man
- He implies he cannot get the idea of the man's burned, "fried" hands off his mind:
 - This highlights the influence of the man's tragic story, and [foreshadows](#) change



**"You mean some unions don't. It used to be that way, but things have changed" —
The union man**

Meaning and context

- John dismisses the union organiser's advice to attend a meeting, telling him that unions are only for white men
- The union man corrects him, telling him that only "some" are racially segregated
- He says that racism within the unions is decreasing over time

Analysis

- Ellison's union man represents the idea of change in America
- His correction "some unions don't" contrasts John's pessimism and suspicion
- Although John is sceptical initially, the union man's optimistic words influence John, and contribute to his more hopeful attitude by the end of the narrative



"Maybe there was a color other than white on the old ball" — John

Meaning and context

- The final line of the story presents a changed John:
 - He thinks there may be a chance his son will have a better future
- He says that maybe the "ball" thrown by the white boy, for which his own son was blamed, will become less "white" in the future

Analysis

- Ellison's symbolic "white" and "black" ball presents the idea of racism via a child's toy:
 - This highlights the significance of John's son in the story
- The ending illustrates how fatherhood helps to motivate action:
 - John's hope for a better future for his son encourages him to change



Your notes

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Your notes



The Gold Watch analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to The Gold Watch by Mulk Raj Anand contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of The Gold Watch

Mulk Raj Anand, born in 1905, is the influential Indian author of short story The Gold Watch, which depicts the influence of the **British Empire** in India.

The **protagonist**, Srijut Sudarshan Sharma, is a dispatch clerk who works for the "Marmalade Empire of Henry King & Co." in Bombay. A loyal and polite worker for 20 years, he plans to stay five more years before he retires.

One day, one of his British bosses, Mr Acton, comes to tell him that he has something for him, and that he will get it on Monday. Sharma is surprised. Usually his boss ignores him and the other workers. He remembers the odd look on Mr Acton's face, and worries that his boss is about to give him a retirement gift.

When he finds out from Mr Acton that the gift is a gold watch with a special inscription, he spends an anxious weekend at home, concerned he will not be able to provide for his family. He tells his wife and son about it, and gives his son his own silver watch.

On Monday Mr Acton presents him with the gold watch as compensation for an early retirement. Sharma is distraught and drops it (although his boss says it still works, Sharma finds out later that it has been broken). Furious that he is being forced out, but unable to protest, Sharma says nothing and leaves. His colleagues admire the watch and comment on Mr Acton's generosity.

On the long journey home, Sharma reflects that it does not matter if the watch is broken since, now he is retired, he will not need to know the time.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. This will help

you to form a structural analysis, which means you will be considering how themes and characters develop (or not) through the story.



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in The Gold Watch

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Mulk Raj Anand's *The Gold Watch*.

What are the key themes in The Gold Watch?

Theme	Analysis
Exploitation	▪ The story illustrates the vulnerable status of Indian employees in a British company in colonial Bombay: ▪ The protagonist, Sharma, is reliant on his job to support his family and afford his retirement ▪ Anand shows a hierarchical system in the British company where Sharma works: ▪ The British Mr West and Mr Acton are referred to with the title "Sahib" (Sir) ▪ The workers, the narrator says, are generally ignored: ▪ Only "twice or thrice a year" was he "called into the cubicle by West Sahib for a reprimand" ▪ Anand describes Sharma as submissive: ▪ "He withdrew in the abject manner of his ancestors" as if he was retreating from "feudal lords" ▪ Anand shows how Mr Acton's politeness covers up ageism: ▪ The watch is presented as a reward, so Sharma feels obliged to accept early retirement without protest
Disappointment	▪ Anand creates pathos to evoke reader sympathy for Sharma, and, thus, for all elderly Indian employees ▪ Anand builds suspense through the promise of a special gift: ▪ This presents Sharma's sense of insecurity and powerlessness as a result of his poor treatment ▪ Emotive language exemplifies Sharma's doubt in himself:

- He is “trembling with trepidation, pale and completely unsure of himself”



Your notes

Writer's methods in The Gold Watch

How does Mulk Raj Anand present his ideas and perspectives?

In his short story The Gold Watch, Mulk Raj Anand highlights oppressive **colonial** influence by presenting a sympathetic, elderly dispatch clerk who is forced to graciously accept early retirement from a British marmalade company because he is given a gold watch.

Technique	Analysis
Symbolism	■ Anand uses the symbol of a special gift, an inscribed gold watch, to represent the imbalance of power in a British-run firm in India: ■ The story's protagonist, Sharma, is emotionally manipulated by the gift: its “inscription” will “please you”, his boss says ■ That the watch is broken when he leaves is symbolic of the broken contract between British authority figures and Indian citizens ■ Anand represents the British Empire through the “great Marmalade Empire of Henry King & Co”: ■ The name of the firm connotes to royalty and grandness ■ Anand symbolises the wealth divide in colonial India: ■ The manager gets into a “polished Buick” ■ The Indian clerk, Sharma, must get a “train to Thana, thirty miles out where he had resided, for cheapness”



Your notes

Omniscient narrator	■ The omniscient narrator reveals Sharma's inner turmoil, and how it is caused by imbalances of power: ■ He shows Sharma's sense of anticipation at being singled out and possibly rewarded for his loyalty and hard work ■ As events unfold, the narrator shows the gradual diminishment of Sharma's confidence and hope: ■ He writes: "He felt a pull at his heart. He paused for breath and tried to calm himself. The blood pressure! Or was it merely wind?" ■ The narrator illustrates how Mr Acton's fake kindness reduces Sharma's dignity: ■ "These words hypnotised Sharma"
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Examiner Tips and Tricks

Writers often highlight certain ideas because of the time and place in which their story is written. Examiners reward essay responses that explore the meanings of the text in their contexts, so this should inform your response.

For instance, you could write about how, in the short story *The Gold Watch*, Mulk Raj Anand describes the oppressive influence of the **British Empire** in India. In other words, you should explore the text beyond surface meanings and show your understanding of the themes the writer is raising, and why they may have been raised.

Key quotations in *The Gold Watch*

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. Remember, though, summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referencing plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Mulk Raj Anand's *The Gold Watch*, arranged by the following themes:

- **Exploitation**
- **Disappointment**

Exploitation

Anand highlights the impact of **exploitative** attitudes on a **marginalised** Indian clerk, and how it leads to his suffering.



“The poor old dispatch clerk could not surmise the real meaning of the General Manager’s remark” — Narrator



Your notes

Meaning and context

- Srijut Sharma is an elderly “clerk” experiencing financial hardship
- When the General Manager says he has a gift for him, Sharma finds it difficult to understand because, usually, the managers are known for their meanness

Analysis

- Anand introduces his **protagonist** as sympathetic:
 - He is fifty years old with a family he works hard to support
- Anand highlights the suspicion with which Sharma greets any kindness from his boss



“A morose, old Sahib, hard working, conscientious and a slave driver, famous as a shrewd businessman, so devoted to the job of spreading the monopoly of King’s Marmalade” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Sharma calls his boss, Mr Acton, “Sahib”, meaning “Sir”
- He is described as miserable, a good “businessman”, and focused on work
- He insists on hard work from his employees because he is loyal to the British Empire

Analysis

- Anand contrasts Sharma, who is focused on his family, with the boss, who is “devoted” to his work, to highlight different cultural values
- The description “slave driver” connotes to **exploitative** behaviour
- Anand’s humorous description of Mr Acton’s desperation to “spread” the “King’s marmalade” alludes to making money for the **monopolising British Empire**



“Srijut Sharma tried to voice his inner protest in words which would convey his meaning without seeming to be disloyal” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- When the boss gives Sharma a gold watch as compensation for early retirement, Sharma cannot speak up or “protest” even though he wants to
- He is not sure how to turn down the gift without seeming “disloyal” to the company

Analysis

- Anand illustrates Sharma’s powerlessness to stand up for his rights
- He is emotionally manipulated to accept poor treatment and injustice out of fear of punishment

Disappointment



“But then Srijut Sharma was, in spite of his nobility of soul and fundamental innocence, experienced enough in his study of the vague, detached race of the white Sahibs by now” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Sharma is confused by Mr Acton’s smile at first
- But, even though he is naturally tolerant and likes to give people the benefit of the doubt, he reminds himself that the “white” bosses (“Sahibs”) are “detached”:
 - Sharma has experienced their aloof, indifferent attitudes before

Analysis

- Anand contrasts the callousness of **colonial** bosses with the “innocent” and noble Indian worker, Sharma
- His description of the “white” bosses is **sardonic**, and suggests that, even someone who is forgiving and good-natured can become **cynical**



“There was no other explanation. His doom was sealed” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- When Sharma goes home, he reflects on Mr Acton’s promise of a gold watch with an inscription, but decides that the gift means he is going to be fired
- Having thought about it, he concludes this is the only possible “explanation”

Analysis



Your notes

- Anand's **omniscient narrator** presents Sharma's disappointment in two short sentences
- The sense of **pathos** created by his resignation to his fate, or his "sealed" "doom", shows the injustice of the situation, and highlights his lack of **autonomy**



Your notes



"In Jullunder, where time just stood still and no one bothered about keeping appointments" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- As Sharma contemplates his future (his retirement in "Jullunder", a city in Punjab), he realises he will not need a watch
- When he is retired in Punjab, away from the city and without work, he will not need to tell the time nor keep appointments

Analysis

- The story ends with a **metaphor**, "time just stood still", which alludes to the broken watch and Sharma's retirement
- The sad ending suggests an obscure and meaningless future for Sharma
- The **irony** of the redundant retirement gift illustrates the lack of care and interest offered to the company's employees

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.

<https://www.ijfmr.com/papers/2025/2/42144.pdf>.

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When It Happens analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to When It Happens by Margaret Atwood contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of When It Happens

Margaret Atwood's short story When It Happens was written in 1977. Atwood is best known for **dystopian** fiction, such as her influential novel A Handmaid's Tale. Her story When It Happens blends the past and the present with ideas about a bleak futuristic world.

The story begins describing the middle-aged Mrs Burridge, the **protagonist**, who is pickling tomatoes in preparation for a cold chill. She and her husband live on a farm. Although their life is comfortable enough, even mundane in its routine, Mrs Burridge has a worrying concern which she cannot shift. When she stares outside, she imagines seeing smoke. When she pickles tomatoes, she cannot help but wonder if she is prepared for when "it happens".

The **omniscient narrator** does not explicitly say what "it" is, but Mrs Burridge's thoughts reflect on the rising prices, food shortages, and news of "strikes" and "lay offs". She remembers what happened during the **Great Depression** and the war, and how the media went silent, how the oil and gas stopped coming, and so she knows what to expect. She cannot speak of her worries though; her neighbours and husband appear to want to ignore it and carry on as usual (she says her husband likes things to go as expected).

As Mrs Burridge writes a shopping list, she goes through the details of her escape plan. Despite all the food she has stored, she knows this will not help. She knows her husband will go towards the "smoke" and never return, so she must look after herself. She must prepare for when her house and farm is taken over and ransacked. She will need to free the chickens and dogs. She must take only as much as she can carry. She must have a gun and be prepared to use it.

The story ends with Mrs Burridge returning to her shopping list, and going back to the door.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in When It Happens

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Margaret Atwood's *When It Happens*.

What are the key themes in *When It Happens*?

Theme	Analysis
Fear and isolation	- Atwood conveys Mrs Burridge's constant fear about the future as she carries out domestic tasks - Her fear is informed and heightened by her experiences during the Great Depression and the "war": - This helps Atwood present her story as a warning - The nervous Mrs Burridge is "practical", not paranoid - Mrs Burridge is isolated in her concerns: - Neither her husband nor friends will "talk about it" - The people in town have an "air of helplessness" - This isolation leads her to lie to her husband as she cannot share her worries
Utopia and dystopia	- The story represents the idea of a utopia as an abundance of food, a home, and memories of family - The idea of dystopia is represented by the ideas of food insecurity, a lack of warmth and light, and criminal behaviour - Atwood contrasts the Burridges' abundant and comfortable life with an inevitably bleak future - The farm is thriving and they always have too much: - There were "three bushels" of green tomatoes picked from the garden - Contrastingly, the future is described with something "burning, smoke coming up from the horizon":



Your notes

	- There will be insecurity and destruction - Telephone wires "are blown down in a storm"
The past and the future	- Atwood's narrator reflects Mrs Burridge's meandering thoughts which alternate between her chores and an imminent crisis: - She plans to make a "lemon meringue", and "When the pickles are cool she labels them" - She remembers the "war", and prepares herself for a future in which the media will become "non-committal" - Mrs Burridge's certainty about the future is reflected in the references to "when" (not "if") it happens

Writer's methods in When It Happens

How does Margaret Atwood present her ideas and perspectives?

In Atwood's short story When It Happens, an imagined **apocalyptic** event is told from the unlikely perspective of a middle-aged wife and mother.

Technique	Analysis
Symbolism	- Atwood's story presents the idea of peace as a life of safety and routine: - Even seemingly negative things like Frank's "pig-headedness", her "nagging", his complaints, and her teasing reflects the constancy and reliability of their lives - Atwood uses the symbol of "smoke" to represent a future crisis: - Mrs Burridge imagines seeing something burning on the "horizon" - Mrs Burridge's comfortable life of abundance is juxtaposed with a future that leaves her without her home, food security, or support: - Atwood presents a dystopian future with the idea of uncertainty - Mrs Burridge's fear of the unknown is conveyed in questions - She asks herself, "What if she is wrong and Frank comes back after all, what if nothing, really, is the matter?" - She is unsure about her husband: "Maybe you'll go off somewhere when it happens"



Your notes

Omniscient narrator	■ The third-person narrator tracks Mrs Burridge's thoughts and feelings: ■ The effect is that the reader knows her inner thoughts better than her husband and children, which creates pathos despite the detached perspective ■ Readers are not told Mrs Burridge's first name, which reflects Mrs Burridge's reserved, practical nature: ■ Not naming Mrs Burridge emphasises her anonymity and ordinariness, allowing her to represent many women of her generation
Tenses	■ Atwood blends tenses to show connections between the past and the present, and how it informs the future: ■ Present tense verbs are used to describe current events: "Mrs. Burridge is putting up green tomato pickles" ■ But this is used in visions of the future as well: "It is about this time too that she takes one of the guns" ■ Simultaneously, Mrs Burridge slips into memories: "She remembers it especially because her daughter Sarah was on the way" ■ Atwood may be implying that for Mrs Burridge, her imagined future is just as real as her present activities



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward essay responses that examine the ways in which writers use language, structure and form to explore deeper ideas, and present certain attitudes. Because of this, it is better to focus your analysis on techniques rather than quotes.

In other words, you could write, for instance: "Margaret Atwood uses a **third-person omniscient narrator** in her story *When It Happens* to create a detached mood, which reflects her protagonist's sense of isolation.

When It Happens key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations, though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Margaret Atwood's *When It Happens*, arranged by the following themes:



Your notes

- **Fear and isolation**
- **Utopia and dystopia**
- **The past and the future**

Fear and isolation

Margaret Atwood's chilling short story *When It Happens* depicts a middle-aged wife's silent anxiety about a dangerous future which she is certain she will face alone.



"It doesn't make her feel safe any more" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator says that Mrs Burridge does not feel safe having all the stored food in the cellar, although it used to make her feel prepared for a crisis or being "cut off"

Analysis

- Although Atwood uses an **omniscient narrator**, short sentences reflect tension in Mrs Burridge's voice, or inner thoughts
- The present tense verb "doesn't" creates immediacy, which heightens tension
- Atwood may be suggesting an urgent need to think about an unsafe future



"She feels beleaguered, isolated, like someone shut up inside a fortress" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- When Mrs Burridge imagines the future, she sees her house as a prison
- She knows that because she has plenty of food and the promise of warmth her home will be attacked, and this makes her feel blockaded in and trapped

Analysis

- Atwood illustrates how powerlessness leads to fear:
 - Mrs Burridge has done all she can to prepare, but she believes it is in vain
- A **simile** compares her home to a "fortress":

- This both reflects its ability to offer security and also its potential to be a prison that isolates her and leaves her vulnerable



Your notes

Utopia and dystopia



“She is gazing around the kitchen, looking at all the things she will have to leave behind when she goes” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- As Mrs Burridge looks around her kitchen at all the things she will miss, she feels sad she will have to leave the comfortable home she has with her husband

Analysis

- Atwood implies that Mrs Burridge’s simple kitchen represents a happy, simple life:
 - She suggests that the time and memories invested in making a comfortable home bring a sense of peace, even representing a **utopia**
- This is **juxtaposed** with her certainty that she will lose it all



“They have spotted her gun, their eyes have fastened on it, they want it” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- In Mrs Burridge’s imagined future, she is alone in a forest
- Some men see her gun and they stare at it as they plan how to take it from her

Analysis

- Atwood describes an **anarchic** future in which survival comes by any means possible:
 - Pauses in a list of the men’s every action reflect Mrs Burridge’s vulnerable position and fearful alertness
- Atwood describes a **dystopian** future that is rife with crime and violence

The past and the future



“She thinks of her girls now and hopes they will not have babies; it is no longer the right time for it” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Mrs Burridge reflects on her daughters, and hopes they do not decide to have children because the world has changed, and a crisis is imminent

Analysis

- Atwood's blunt narration emphasises Mrs Burridge's **pragmatism** and practicality
- Through her **protagonist**, Atwood implies individuals find it necessary to prepare for the future realistically and without emotion or **nostalgia**



“It used to annoy Mrs. Burridge, especially the crumbs, but now she watches him with a kind of sadness; she once thought their life together would go on forever but she has come to realize this is not the case” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Mrs Burridge reflects on her changing attitude towards her husband
- There was a time she found his little habits annoying, but now that she knows she will face the future alone, she feels a sense of “sadness”

Analysis

- Atwood **poignantly** depicts the growing barrier between Mrs Burridge and her husband because of her silent concern for the future
- Through Mrs Burridge's **morbid** thoughts and certainty that her husband will not survive, Atwood shows how thoughts about the future impact the present

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Your notes



The Man Who Walked on the Moon analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to The Man Who Walked on the Moon by J.G. Ballard contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of The Man Who Walked on the Moon

The **first-person** narrator of J.G. Ballard's short story The Man Who Walked on the Moon introduces himself as a former astronaut. He is sitting at a Copacabana Beach cafe in Brazil. He explains that he has been abandoned by his family and government, and has amnesia, and resorts to begging off "American tourists". The narrator is confused about parts of his life, but he is certain he was once an "astronaut".

The narrator admits he was once an unpopular, failing journalist and feels the pressure of disappointing everyone. On a mission to find a "human-interest story" for his editors, he finds himself intrigued by a middle-aged man sitting in a cafe. The man is Mr Scranton, who says he is a former space commander, although he looks impoverished. He attracts a lot of tourists. They pay him to tell them about his time as an astronaut, and have their picture taken.

The envious narrator finds out that Mr Scranton was never an astronaut and just a "crop-duster" who lost his pilot license, but this increases his interest in the fraudster. He approaches him for an interview, and when Scranton invites him back to his apartment to show him some photographs, he goes.

There, he is disappointed to find out that the photographs are just news cuttings. Nevertheless, he is fascinated with Mr Scranton's sense of peace. The narrator comes to the conclusion that Mr Scranton is like an astronaut as he is able to look at the world in a detached and distant way.

As Mr Scranton's health deteriorates, the narrator cares for him, although he never calls a doctor. Eventually, Mr Scranton's ill health leads to his death, at which point the narrator takes to living in the flat. By this stage, his own state of mind has worsened; he says he enjoys the freedom that comes from purposelessness and loneliness, as if he sees the world from space.

He goes to the cafe at the beach, and begins to tell tourists that he used to be an astronaut.



Your notes



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).

Themes, ideas and perspectives in The Man Who Walked on the Moon

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in J.G. Ballard's *The Man Who Walked on the Moon*.

What are the key themes in The Man Who Walked on the Moon?

Theme	Analysis
Identity	▪ The short story explores the psychological impacts of depression and isolation: ▪ The narrator feels that he used to amount to “nothing” ▪ His sense of disconnection from his family and work colleagues makes him suspicious and self-pitying ▪ The chance encounter with another man who looks to be similarly disenchanted with the world leads to a transformation: ▪ Ballard shows how the narrator becomes envious of the ease at which Scranton makes a living ▪ The story raises issues about an individual's position in the world, and the idea of purposefulness: ▪ While Scranton's state of being offers him peace and contentment, it is based on a lie
Reality and delusion	▪ Ballard uses the symbolic idea of being an astronaut, far from the world, to represent distancing oneself from reality ▪ He uses imagery that describes “shadows” and an “empty world” to represent the state of delusion



Your notes

	- Ballard's story reveals how the narrator, finding reality burdensome, is tempted towards a comfortable, numbing lie: - American tourists play into this delusion, which illustrates the temptation of fantasy - Ballard shows the narrator's growing nihilism as he chooses to immerse himself in a lie and become Scranton: - He fails to get medical help for the ailing Scranton, and ignores the concerned doctor in the final days
Freedom	- Ballard's story reflects the American preoccupation with space travel after World War II: - The idea of an astronaut alludes to a childhood dream, and the idea of heroism - After the Apollo programme, astronauts were celebrated - The admiration Scranton receives from tourists is alluring to the narrator, and he becomes envious - The symbolic image of being in space, looking down on the earth, offers the narrator freedom from the challenges of life: - He describes the city "yielding" to him, and that there was a "loosening air" once he sees it differently

Writer's methods in The Man Who Walked on the Moon

How does J.G. Ballard present his ideas and perspectives?

In the short story *The Man Who Walked on the Moon*, Ballard's flawed narrator finds his reality challenging. To avoid the disappointments and trials of life, and in a bid to regain some self-confidence, he is drawn to a deception.

Technique	Analysis
Cyclical narrative	- Ballard uses a cyclical structure to present his narrator as trapped in his alternate reality: - The story begins with the line: "I, too, was once an astronaut" - It ends with the line, "Yes, I am the astronaut" - Ballard implies the narrator faces the same fate as Scranton when he moves into his flat - Ballard uses the representation of an "astronaut" to symbolise the delusional state of Mr Scranton and, then, the narrator:



Your notes

	▪ There is irony in the way the narrator introduces himself ▪ He says he is confident in his “sense” of “true history and worth” ▪ The rest of the story relates his decline into a delusional and detached state, which makes him, essentially, worthless
Unreliable narrator	▪ The short story is told from the first-person point of view to reveal the troubled mindset of the flawed narrator: ▪ The narrator is confused and cannot remember things clearly ▪ He is self-pitying and feels “abandoned”, but admits he is unpopular because of his “reticence” and “sharpness” ▪ His editors “laugh at” him, and his wife resents him ▪ He says all his effort “failed to get me to the top” ▪ The narrator’s gradual decline in mental health stems from his need to escape the responsibilities of life: ▪ “Their faces became invisible” ▪ Being alone, without clear purpose, allows him, like Scranton, some distance from pressures, but he loses a sense of reality: ▪ He decides that the photos of “Armstrong” and the other astronauts is a picture of he and Scranton walking “on the moon of this world”



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward essay responses that sensitively consider the writer’s use of language, structure and form. This means you should explore how literary techniques convey meaning, reveal deeper ideas, and imply certain attitudes.

Consider things like the writer’s choice of narrator. Who is telling the story and what does this character represent? Remember, the narrator is not the author. Authors create characters that will effectively explore their themes or raise certain issues with which they are concerned.

The Man Who Walked on the Moon key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations,

though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from J.G. Ballard's *The Man Who Walked on the Moon*, arranged by the following themes:

- Identity
- Reality and delusion
- Freedom

Identity



“You probably assume that I am a man of few achievements. The shabby briefcase between my worn heels, the stained suit with its stained cuffs, the unsavoury hands ready to seize the first offer of a free drink” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator says that readers might think he is a “failure” because he looks like he is poor, does not have a good job, is dirty, drinks, and relies on charity

Analysis

- Ballard introduces a question about the meaning of success in a **direct address**
- Ballard critiques modern capitalist ideals of success — the office job, self-sufficiency, outward respectability — which the narrator rejects in favour of delusion
- The narrator implies this is not true, and that he has found an alternative



“Around me were the million faces of the city. People strode past, so occupied with their own lives that they almost pushed me from the pavement” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator feels the tension of city life, with its citizens rushing and panicked
- Everyone is focused on themselves, and this makes him feel unseen and alone

Analysis

- Ballard suggests that city life can bring a sense of chaos for an individual
- Ballard's narrator notices his society is self-absorbed, and this leaves him isolated



Your notes

- Ballard's story may imply that modern life can lead to an identity crisis

Reality and delusion



Your notes



"Then an over-curious reporter exploded the whole pretence" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator feels sympathetic towards Mr Scranton even though he is deceiving American tourists and pretending to be a former astronaut
- He says that he found out that Mr Scranton was actually a small aeroplane pilot who lost his license

Analysis

- Ballard shows how his narrator is tempted by Mr Scranton's similarly impoverished and disappointing life, and that he feels a sense of connection with him:
 - The reader, however, sees him supporting deception, rather than the truth
- The narrator chooses delusion, believing that he has been putting up a "facade" at work anyway, and that that kind of lie got him nowhere:
 - This way, Ballard offers a subtle critique on a **hypocritical** society



"He and I were the only real inhabitants of the city" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator says that only he attended Scranton's funeral
- However, this is appropriate as he believes that they are the only "real" people in the city

Analysis

- Ballard presents his **unreliable narrator** as confident and certain:
 - This signals his clear delusion in the face of such strange comments
 - At the same time, Ballard raises questions about the meaning of truth, exploring alternative perspectives on versions of reality
- Ballard shows how the narrator fails to see the significance of Scranton's poorly attended funeral:
 - This is used as [foreshadowing](#)
 - His delusion prevents him from seeing his likely future

Freedom



Your notes



“I gazed down corridors of light that ran between them like the aisles of an open-air cathedral” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- When the narrator travels on the tram, he sees things from Scranton's perspective
- He describes the tram “aisles” as full of “light”, as if he is in a church

Analysis

- Ballard uses a [simile](#) to make an unlikely comparison, which highlights the narrator's strange mindset:
 - The tram “aisles” are like those of a “cathedral”
- The **imagery** in “corridors of light” alludes to a moment of **epiphany**
- Ballard implies the narrator feels a sense of freedom, like a religious awakening, when he begins to see the world from a detached viewpoint



“I, too, had walked on the moon” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- By the end of the story, the narrator is entirely delusional, believing himself to be an astronaut because he and Scranton had both “seen” the “void”
- The narrator is free from all previous worries now that he believes he has walked on the moon

Analysis

- Ballard's calm narrator raises questions about how lies and self-deception bring freedom from the worries of life, and an escape from the need to be a success
- The [metaphor](#) of walking on the moon represents the sense of exceptionalism the narrator enjoys in his fantasy:
 - This, he thinks, is better than feeling invisible in the real world

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



A Walk to the Jetty analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to A Walk to the Jetty by Jamaica Kincaid contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of A Walk to the Jetty

Written in 1985, Kincaid's novel Annie John is set in Antigua during the 1950s and 1960s, a time during which Antigua was under **British colonial** rule. Its last chapter is called A Walk to the Jetty.

In this chapter, the young female **protagonist**, Annie, is preparing to leave her childhood home in Antigua to embark on a voyage to England. On her last morning in her childhood home she reflects on all the things she will leave behind. She is reminded of happy times, but she is also very happy that this will be the last time she sees her house and her parents. Annie says she does not want to go to England, but she will go anywhere to get away from home.

After a tense breakfast, during which she looks at her parents with "disgust" and tells her mother she will never marry like she did, Annie and her parents set off for the docks. On the way, under a blue sky, she takes in all the familiar sights, reminding herself that this will be the last time she will see them. She remembers moments of her childhood, friends she used to love, and, as she goes, she smiles politely as people say goodbye and wish her luck, feeling a disconnection to them all.

Eventually, she arrives and must walk on to the jetty. She worries, as she always has, that she will fall through the wooden planks into the water. Annie's nervousness about her trip is mixed with her desperation to leave. When she boards the ship she must remember to wave goodbye to her parents, and, then, she and the ship grow smaller as they enter the open sea. The chapter ends with a nervous Annie listening to the strange sounds of the waves.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the plot. You will need to be

able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in *A Walk to the Jetty*

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Jamaica Kincaid's *A Walk to the Jetty*.

What are the key themes in *A Walk to the Jetty*?

Theme	Analysis
Identity	▪ Kincaid presents the transition from adolescence to adulthood as uncomfortable: ▪ Annie says that she "did not want to go to England" nor did she want to "be a nurse" ▪ However, she would prefer to be living in a "cavern and keeping house for seven unruly men" rather than stay ▪ Annie says she is "shoulder to shoulder" with her parents, so it is "not very comfortable to walk" together ▪ The walk to the jetty symbolises her childhood: ▪ She feels detached from the people around her ▪ She feels she has "drifted apart" from her friends ▪ She repeatedly reminds herself to take in all the memories for the "last time" ▪ Her childhood memories are represented by places she passes: ▪ As she passes the unkind seamstress' house, Annie is happy to place her on the "dustheap" of her life ▪ She remembers the church where she was christened, and the route to the chemist on her first walk alone
Family relationships	▪ Kincaid illustrates a teenager's growing sense of defiance as they desire independence from their parents: ▪ Annie is sarcastic when she describes photographs of people she is "supposed to love forever no matter what" ▪ She is happy to never again hear her mother "gargling" ▪ She tells her mother that it is "absurd" to get married



Your notes

	■ Annie accepts that her relationship with her family is changing: ■ She says she is “apart” and they are “together” ■ Kincaid illustrates how the vast age difference between Annie and her father cause a barrier: ■ She describes her father as ill and old, with “false teeth” ■ He does not talk about the “personal” things that she likes to
Cultural differences	■ Kincaid reveals the British colonial influence in Antigua: ■ Their “grooming aids” are “imported from London” ■ Annie likes the talcum powder that comes in a tin with images of Victorian England on it ■ She attends “Brownie meetings” and “Sunday school” ■ At the same time, Annie describes the native creole culture: ■ Her father drinks “herbs and barks that he boils in water” instead of the “medicine the doctor has ordered” ■ Her mother gives Annie clothes and jewellery given by the “obeah” women to protect her from “evil spirits” ■ Annie describes how the “poor people lived near the shore” under the “hot sun” and “blue sky”

Writer's methods in A Walk to the Jetty

How does Jamaica Kincaid present her ideas and perspectives?

In Kincaid's A Walk to the Jetty, a young girl presents her perspectives on her childhood in Antigua. Kincaid illustrates the cultural differences between Annie, the narrator, and her family and friends as she prepares herself for a new life in England. Kincaid may imply that it is necessary to criticise — and even reject — your childhood in order to move away from it.

Technique	Analysis
First-person narrator	■ Kincaid creates a <u>coming-of-age</u> story by relating the personal development of a young girl becoming independent ■ The <u>first-person</u> voice is introspective and self aware, a mostly credible narrator: ■ She says: “When I look at things in a certain way, I suppose I should say that the two of them made me with their own hands” ■ Her individuality is represented by her rebellious and defiant voice:



Your notes

	▪ “I never wanted to lie in my bed again” is repeated in anaphora ▪ Annie’s mixed emotions about her childhood illustrate her complex identity: ▪ She describes familiar places as strange to her now, “as if they were hanging in the air”, alluding to the state of limbo she is in
Symbolism	▪ Kincaid uses Annie’s house to represent barriers between a teenager and their parents: ▪ The house, Annie says, belongs to them, not her ▪ She repeats a list of all the things her “father built with his own hands” and her mother “mother made with her own hands” ▪ The jetty she must cross to board the ship and leave Antigua symbolises childhood fear: ▪ She has the “old fear” of falling through into the “dark-green” water, where the “dark-green eels” live ▪ The sea represents the separation and distance between Annie and her family home: ▪ She describes her mother as “a dot in the matchbox-size launch swallowed up in the big blue sea”



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward essay responses that sensitively consider the writer’s use of language, structure and form. This means you should explore how literary techniques convey meaning, reveal deeper ideas, and imply certain attitudes.

Consider things like the writer’s choice of narrator. Who is telling the story and what does this character represent? Remember, the narrator is not the author. Authors create characters that will effectively explore their themes or raise certain issues with which they are concerned. For instance, in *A Walk to the Jetty*, Jamaica Kincaid shows the intimate thoughts of a young teenage girl in order to raise themes about changing family values.

A Walk to the Jetty key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations, though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Jamaica Kincaid's *A Walk to the Jetty*, arranged by the following themes:



Your notes

- Identity
- Family relationships
- Cultural differences

Identity



"Everywhere I looked stood something that had meant a lot to me" — Annie

Meaning and context

- Annie looks around her bedroom on her last morning in Antigua and sees all the things that used to be so important to her

Analysis

- Annie's observation of the things that used to represent a part of her identity as a child is in past tense:
 - The fact that they "had" meant a lot to me implies that this is no longer true
- Kincaid shows the rather emotionless response of a teen girl desperate to leave home, and feeling a disconnection with her past



"All the things I used to feel are as false as the teeth in my father's head" — Annie

Meaning and context

- Annie recognises her changing identity:
 - She feels completely differently about everything now
- The truths she used to believe are now as "false" as her elderly father's fake teeth

Analysis

- Kincaid's humorous [simile](#) raises ideas about the the word "false", which is used to emphasise her father's age and to represent untruths in her previous beliefs
- Annie is presented as self-aware, and, perhaps, a little alarmed at how much she is changing as an individual and forming a completely new set of values

Family relationships



“I felt that someone was tearing me up into little pieces and soon I would be able to see all the little pieces as they floated out into nothing in the deep blue sea” — Annie



Your notes

Meaning and context

- When Annie boards the ship to leave her family and home forever, she is distressed, describing her feelings as if she was being torn apart into small fragments
- She says that the person she was is being reduced to “nothing” by the voyage as it is ripping her from her family and past

Analysis

- Kincaid’s [metaphor](#) of Annie becoming fragments of herself describes the process of growing up and finding independence as painful and frightening:
 - The sea represents the distance created between Annie and her home
 - She compares herself to paper, suggesting that she is fragile and easily destroyed by the water:
 - It’s as if her identity is breaking up
- The long sentence reflects Annie’s sense of becoming overwhelmed and panicking



“The road for me now went only in one direction: away from my home, away from my mother, away from my father, away from the everlasting blue sky” — Annie

Meaning and context

- Annie tries to remember that she has no choice but to leave
- She focuses on her future (the “road”) which can only lead her away from all that she knows, and everything that represents her childhood

Analysis

- Kincaid reveals Annie’s anxious thoughts as she veers between desperation, sadness, and determined self-control
- Her strength of will is conveyed in **anaphora** where she lists the things from which she needs to be “away”

Cultural differences





“I placed a mark against obeah women, jewelry, and white underclothes” — Annie



Your notes

Meaning and context

- As Annie looks at everything for the last time, she decides whether they are good or bad, to be remembered or discarded
- One of the things she decides to discard, or place a “mark” next to, is the “**obeah** women” who give her clothes and “jewelry” that contain magical spells

Analysis

- Kincaid shows the tensions between old and new culture, and the influence of **British colonialism** on a teenager in Antigua, a British colony in the Caribbean
- Annie is keen to distance herself from the spiritual traditions which her mother continues, such as warding off evil spirits with special clothing and jewellery



“...my mother had, as a special favor, let me use her own talcum powder, which smelled quite perfumy and came in a can that had painted on it people going out to dinner in nineteenth-century London” — Annie

Meaning and context

- Annie describes how she was allowed to wear her mother’s special “talcum powder”, which came from “London”
- She describes the fragrant scent and how its tin has pictures of Victorian English ladies and gentlemen painted on it

Analysis

- Annie’s coming of age is symbolised by the move from Antigua to England:
 - She is happy that she is able to use the fancy talcum powder from England rather than the “baby-smelling” powder she usually uses
- Kincaid shows how England represents Annie’s future, one she believes will be sophisticated and very different to her childhood home

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Showing the Flag analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Showing the Flag by Jane Gardam contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Showing the Flag

Jane Gardam's short story Showing the Flag depicts a young teenage boy, Philip, leaving his mother, Gwen, and his English home to travel to France. His mother is sad to see him go again (she says he has been going to boarding schools since he was six years old). Gwen's friend Miss Pym reminds her that this is the "custom" in England and children must learn to "endure".

Philip waves goodbye and spends some time looking at the seagulls as he hangs over the ship's railings. He starts thinking about food, and what it will be like in France, and then about the **Union Jack** flag that he has in a little tin. His mother has packed him the small flag to pin to his coat when he arrives in France. This is to identify him to Major Foster, a French-Canadian, who is to meet Philip when he arrives. Philip wants to look at the flag, so he takes it out of the tin, but it blows away.

Once in France, Philip finds himself in a crowd of French-speaking people on the quay. In the rush, someone tries to steal his suitcase but he is able to kick him off.

Finally, on the train, he finds a seat, has to defend his suitcase from another "ruffian", and then looks out the window at the strange unfamiliar landscape. He notices the people outside the train. They are full of "confidence" and "daring", unlike the people he knows in England.

He begins to worry about how Major Foster will find him if he has not got the flag on his coat. His thoughts turn to his mother (who always "kept everything right") and overheard comments from her friend Miss Pym. He remembers a night when Miss Pym was unkind to his father who had been singing drinking songs.

As Philip's anxiety grows, he begins to question his mother's love. He remembers that she was in "bed" during his father's funeral, and that she did not cry when Philip boarded the ship. He decides that she is "stupid" not to have sewn the flag onto his coat before he left, or to have packed him a spare one. When the people around him begin to eat, he finds the neatly packed sandwiches his mother has given him. He opens the packaging and finds a spare **Union Jack** flag with a loving note from his mother apologising for "fussing" over him.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Showing the Flag

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Jane Gardam's *Showing the Flag*.

What are the key themes in Showing the Flag?

Theme	Analysis
Family relationships	- Gardam illustrates misunderstandings between a teen boy and his mother, using irony to build sympathy for them both: - Philip thinks his mother's "crying-and-laughing-together" means she is not sad to see him go - Readers see a mother attempting to be strong: - She is in reality "laughing at her weakness" - Philip calls her "stupid" for not packing a spare flag - The story ends with him finding a spare flag in his packed sandwiches with a loving note - Philip's limited understanding of his parents and their relationship results in him doubting his mother's love: - Miss Pym's dialogue reveals that Philip did not know his father well, and his mother, Gwen, "scarcely" saw him - But Philip remembers her "not listening" to his father
Cultural identity	- Gardam's story raises themes about patriotism: - The story's title refers to an idiom about naval ships - Ships would proudly display the flag of their country of origin upon entering a foreign port - The Union Jack is symbolic of Philip's British identity



Your notes

	■ The story reveals how Philip begins to notice differences between the French and the “English”: ■ He refers to the way the English “keep private their secret thoughts” in comparison to the “daring” French ■ He implies this would minimise misunderstandings ■ Gardam raises questions about “the culture of the English middle class”, illustrating how secrets lead to doubt: ■ Philip’s confusion arises as a result of his mother’s attempts at being stoic: she is not “one to break” ■ His memories of her “gone off to bed” for his father’s funeral makes him think she did not care
Independence	■ Gardam depicts barriers between Philip and his mother: ■ He awkwardly kisses her goodbye with a “sliding away of the eyes”, implying he is keen to leave ■ At first, the 13-year-old Philip is childlike, distracted by seagulls, and “scuffing his shoes like a two-year-old”: ■ His first thought is that he is “hungry” ■ Gardam illustrates how Philip becomes anxious as he faces challenges away from the safety of his mother’s care: ■ He imagines that his mother and Miss Pym are happy he is gone, that they “got rid of him together” ■ Gardam shows how Philip is determined to “manage” alone: ■ He decides his mother is “stupid” and “wicked” ■ He wards off thieves, plans to find work in France, and decides to make a flag to replace the lost one

Writer's methods in Showing the Flag

In her short story Showing the Flag, Jane Gardam raises questions about the emotional and psychological impact of a young boy’s cultural identity as he leaves his mother for a new country.

Technique	Analysis
Omniscient narrator	■ Gardam uses an omniscient narrator to show both the mother and the son’s perspective so as to convey their different experiences: ■ Philip’s mother, Gwen, “can’t bear” her son leaving her



Your notes

	■ Philip is a little confused when he waves “in vain” at his “laughing” and “weeping” mother who is led away with “streaming cheeks” ■ The third-person narration creates pathos: ■ Gardam introduces Philip sympathetically ■ He has “big ears” and “immense suitcases”, and his “father was dead” ■ Gardam’s poignant stream of consciousness shows Philip’s misunderstandings as a result of his innocence: ■ He thinks: “She did not love him, want him, know him and she never had... She wanted him lost”
Symbolism	■ Gardam uses the symbol of the Union Jack flag to represent Philip’s British identity and his connection to his “English” mother ■ Wry dialogue reveals cultural tensions: ■ Miss Pym suggests it is “rather a lot to expect of a Frenchman” to “wear the English flag”, which alludes to Anglo-French conflicts ■ Gardam may be alluding to national tensions, too, through Miss Pym’s reference to the Union Jack as an “English” flag ■ Gwen says that the “Fosters are French-Canadian” and that they’re “very English”, which alludes to Canada as a British colony ■ Philip’s suitcase is symbolic of a young boy taking on an adult role: ■ Travelling alone to France as a 13-year-old boy, his mother says that his suitcases are “nearly as big as he is” ■ His mother’s love is represented by the way she has packed his suitcase so carefully, and with love and expertise ■ On his travels, Philip is forced to protect his suitcases from thieves, which represents his growing independence



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward essay responses that sensitively consider the writer’s use of language, structure and form. This means you should explore how literary techniques convey meaning, reveal deeper ideas, and imply certain attitudes.

It is almost always worth discussing the writer’s choice of perspective. Who is telling the story and what attitudes are revealed through the narration or inner monologue? Remember, the narrator is not the author. Authors create characters that will

effectively deliver their themes or raise certain issues with which they are concerned. For instance, Jane Gardam reveals the thoughts of both a mother and son in her story so that she can raise themes about family relationships.



Your notes

Showing the Flag key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations, though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Jane Gardam's *Showing the Flag*, arranged by the following themes:

- **Family relationships**
- **Cultural identity**
- **Independence**

Family relationships



"He'd heard them saying in the kitchen that it was her being so perfect had killed his father, though goodness knows, thought Philip, what that meant" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Philip thinks that his mother is to blame for his father's death because he heard "them" (perhaps Miss Pym and his mother's friends) say that she was involved
- He is not sure what they meant when they said his father died because his mother was "perfect"

Analysis

- Gardam shows a young boy's confusion about his parent's relationship, and his unresolved grief over his father's death
- Through Philip's vague memories, Gardam implies that his reserved English upbringing has left him with misunderstandings and doubt about his parents
- Gardam alludes to an imbalanced relationship between Gwen, Philip's mother, and his father, and, importantly, the way things have been hidden from Philip



“How stupid. How stupid of his mother. Why hadn’t she sewed the Union Jack on his raincoat in the first place?” — Narrator



Your notes

Meaning and context

- Philip is annoyed that he has lost the flag that will identify him to Major Foster when he arrives in Paris
- He thinks his mother should have thought to sew the flag on his coat instead of packing it in a tin

Analysis

- Gardam’s **omniscient narrator** takes on Philip’s voice to convey his emotional turmoil about leaving home:
 - Philip’s anxiety about losing his flag is transferred to his mother, whom he blames because she has never let him down before
- Gardam implies, though, that this is Philip’s way to cope with his forced separation

Cultural identity



“Children — it’s all renunciation. Having them is just learning to give them up” — Gwen

Meaning and context

- Gwen, Philip’s mother says that parenthood is all about abandoning children and learning to lose them
- She is upset that her son has spent so much of his childhood at boarding schools

Analysis

- Gardam presents the English “custom” of sending children to boarding school negatively by presenting a distressed mother who feels she is losing her son
- Gwen’s distress about her son’s constant absence is conveyed in short sentences
- Gwen’s use of the word “renunciation” highlights her painful sense of resignation to English middle-class customs of sending children away, which Philip misinterprets as rejection



“I hope their French is not patriotic. If so there is very little point in Philip going” — Miss Pym

Meaning and context

- Miss Pym makes a witty comment about the French-Canadians who are taking care of Philip in France:
 - Gwen says they are **patriotic** to France and England and are “very English”
- Miss Pym suggests that she hopes they are more “patriotic” to France, or their French may not be of good quality
- She says if Philip does not learn to speak French well, he may as well not go

Analysis

- Gardam highlights the English tradition of going to France, or sending one’s children there, to learn the language, often an indication of status and class
- She **wryly** suggests that if the Fosters are too “English”, they will not speak French very well, and this will make the trip pointless

Independence



“There is a point when every child sees through his parents” — Miss Pym

Meaning and context

- Miss Pym warns Philip that he will one day understand his parents better and see them for who they really are

Analysis

- Gardam’s character Miss Pym raises ideas about **feminism** and family tradition:
 - She is described as “plain-spoken”, discusses “politics”, and she tells Gwen she is “wasted now as a mere mother”
- While Philip dislikes her intensely, calling her “Stinkerpym”, she speaks plainly to him



“Look at *Treasure Island*. You can get on without your mother” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Philip is determined to stay strong on his journey to France without his mother
- He reminds himself of young heroes in a children’s story to encourage himself

Analysis



Your notes

- Gardam's sympathetic portrayal of Philip reveals the complexities of growing up and finding independence
- **Ironically**, Philip looks to children's adventure stories as inspiration for how to manage as an adult in his new life alone

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Your notes



Haywards Heath analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Haywards Heath by Aminatta Forna contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Haywards Heath

When the story begins, the **protagonist**, Attila, is driving to the English town of Haywards Heath. He thinks back to the "youth" at the car-hire desk, and his hired car from the "Prestige" range. He remembers Rosie, and how they shared a joke about the "overseas students" who could not pronounce the name of her home town, "Haywards Heath". Attila has found out where Rosie is from the "London hospital" where he consults as a trauma doctor for displaced populations twice a year.

Readers learn that Attila is visiting England and is excited about his impulsive trip to find Rosie. He reflects on the last time he saw her, and his sudden departure after graduation to go "6,000 miles away".

When he arrives he is surprised to find the address he has been given has directed him to a care home. He finds Rosie in the "day room". He remembers how she pleaded with him to stay, and apologises to her for leaving her all those years before. However, although she says she has a friend called Attila who is coming to visit her soon, Rosie is unable to recognise him.

They go for a walk in the garden, during which Attila is reminded of her cheerful and youthful nature despite her age and **dementia**. She steals a sweet from an elderly woman sitting on a bench, telling him that they are her favourites.

Attila goes back to visit two months later, once he has found the sweets Rosie loves. However, once there, he sees her dancing with one of the African care workers. Attila notices that the man has the same "smooth" skin and little beard that he had when he was young. He sees her place her head on his chest and ask him to dance "another turn, Attila".

He places the box of her favourite "Newbury" sweets on the table and sits down to watch.



Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Haywards Heath

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Aminatta Forna's Haywards Heath.

What are the key themes in Haywards Heath?

Theme	Analysis
Romantic relationships	▪ Forna's story revolves around memories that create bonds between people that last forever: ▪ Attila says that "Haywards Heath" had been a "joke" between him and Rosie for a "long time" ▪ This implies Attila has thought about it for the duration of their separation ▪ Forna reveals the poignant nature of an unresolved romantic relationship: ▪ Although separated for decades, Attila has carried his feelings for Rosie throughout his life ▪ When Rosie fails to remember him, Attila has to find solace in the bathroom ▪ Forna shows the frustration Attila feels when it is revealed that Rosie remembers him, but that she cannot recognise him: ▪ Attila is pleased to hear Rosie's familiar words: "Shall we do another turn, Attila?" ▪ But these words are spoken to a care worker, not him
Individual identity	▪ Forna creates a complex character in Attila: ▪ He spends his life torn between his career as a doctor and his love for Rosie ▪ He used to have a "Malcolm X goatee", which made Rosie pity him ▪ He seems pleased that the English do not stare at him, and that he can pronounce "Haywards Heath"



Your notes

	■ His introspection veers between his own successes and thoughts of Rosie ■ The story details Attila's need for closure and a sense of redemption: ■ Readers learn about his troubled life — although he married, his wife has since died ■ Attila feels regret over his failed romance with Rosie ■ Attila is humbled by unfolding events: ■ At first he is self-absorbed and thinks about his "Jaguar" hire car, annoying youths, and food ■ He chooses not to imagine Rosie has a husband ■ He remembers how she wanted him to stay when they were together
The past and the present	■ Beginning the story with Attila driving to find Rosie, Forna alludes to the metaphorical route of his life: ■ Attila makes an "emergency stop" when the car radio "blasts" out, and he must gather his thoughts ■ Forna introduces Attila as an elderly man thinking back on his youth and puzzled by the "new generation": ■ Ironically, the young man who Rosie dances with at the end of the story reminds her of a young Attila ■ The story progresses through Attila's memories, showing the significant impact of a past decision on his life: ■ His memories of Rosie are nostalgic; he is drawn powerfully to the past, and imagines Rosie as she once was ■ Forna creates pathos with juxtaposition of happy memories against the harsh reality of their present-day realities



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners are looking for responses that demonstrate good knowledge of the text through well-selected references. To do this, identify key words or phrases that very specifically support your point, rather than writing out long quotations. By considering a particular word or phrase you will find it easier to notice patterns or techniques. This will lead to a stronger analysis of the writer's choices and how they achieve their intentions.

Try to notice patterns of verbs, for example. What tense are they in? Do they inform you about the character's mood or attitude? You can then explain how this may convey deeper ideas.



Your notes

Writer's methods in Haywards Heath

How does Forna present her ideas and perspectives?

In her short story Haywards Heath, Aminatta Forna conveys the hopes and disappointments of an elderly man returning to a past love.

Technique	Analysis
Omniscient narrator	- Forna uses an omniscient narrator to show Attila's perspective - The third-person narration creates pathos as his every emotion is revealed: - His "heart beat wildly, and his scalp had shrunk against his skull" - The narrator contrasts the garden where Attila and Rosie feel youthful with the "overheated" "day room" that represents their harsh reality: - The "chrysanthemum"-filled garden creates nostalgia
Symbolism	- Forna represents the path Attila has taken in life with his hire-car, a "Jaguar XJ", which represents financial success: - He is identified by his car when a publican "remembered him, or, more accurately, the Jaguar" - Forna represents Attila's life through the car's gadgets: - That he finds the "satnav" annoying may be symbolic of his age and his sense of misdirection - When he gets there, Rosie's 'home' is not what he had expected - The "car radio", which is set too loud, represents the disconnection he feels to the "new generation" and his sense of frustrated youth - Forna's symbolic use of the "Newbury Fruits" represents the missed romance between Attila and Rosie: - When he finally takes her the sweets, she is in another man's arms

Haywards Heath key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations, though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Aminatta Forna's *Haywards Heath*, arranged by the following themes:

- Romantic relationships
- Individual Identity
- The past and the present

Romantic relationships



"...exhaled all the breath in his lungs at the sound of her name" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- The narrator says that Attila became breathless when he heard Rosie's name mentioned at the "London hospital" where she used to work

Analysis

- Forna shows Attila's strong and lasting feelings for Rosie by emphasising his excitement at simply hearing her name:
 - His reaction is so strong it is physical



"On this slender hope he hung his heart" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Attila hopes that Rosie will remember him when he visits next

Analysis

- Forna's [alliteration](#) in "hope", "hung" and "heart" accentuates the emotive language:
 - Attila is very disappointed to find Rosie in a care home, but he still holds out a vain and desperate "hope" for a rekindled romance
 - Forna implies Attila has a sense of regret over the missed chance to be with Rosie

Individual identity



Your notes



“But he went back to his country anyway, full of ideas of himself, of the future” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Attila's choice to go back home after graduating from university in England was because he had dreams and personal goals

Analysis

- Forna highlights the difficult decision Attila faced choosing between Rosie and a career as a doctor back home:
 - It is implied Attila went back to Africa to help “displaced populations” with “trauma”, and that it was there that his wife was killed in an atrocity
- Forna here raises themes about personal identity and impactful decisions



“She reached out to touch the drops or rain on the leaves” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- When Attila and Rosie are walking in the garden of the care home, Rosie is “youthful”, and takes in the “wonder” of nature by touching the wet leaves

Analysis

- Forna highlights, with **sensory imagery**, Rosie's cheerful nature
- Despite her age and condition, she takes pleasure in simple things
- This may emphasise the sense of loss Attila feels having lived without her

The past and the present



“At the desk he asked for her by her maiden name” — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Attila does not consider Rosie may be married when he visits her at the care home



Your notes

- That he does not know if she has married highlights the length of absence between them

Analysis

- Forna illustrates how Attila's memory of Rosie is limited to their time at university
- This creates suspense, as readers and Attila wait to find out what Rosie is like now
- It also reveals Attila as stuck in the past



"Attila felt light-headed and — somewhat bizarrely — youthful" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- When Attila and Rosie walk in the garden he is taken back to the past and feels excited:
 - In a strange way, she makes him feel young again

Analysis

- Forna creates a sympathetic portrayal of Attila and Rosie's romance:
 - Despite their age, he is "youthful" when he is with her, and this, Forna implies, he has not felt for a long time
- Forna implies Rosie would have brought fun to his life as she used to say he was "too serious"

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Fluke analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Fluke by Romesh Gunsekera contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Fluke

The story begins with a description of Mr Weerakoon, a smartly dressed businessman with a "modern" computer case. He has an air of confidence and energy as he climbs into the back of a taxi. The narrator, Vasantha, the taxi driver, listens to Mr Weerakoon talk about his work. He is on his way to an important marketing meeting.

At the conference venue, Mr Weerakoon asks Vasantha to bring his bags to a meeting room signposted "Marketing: The Secret of Success". The meeting room has a view of a "pool", "coconut trees", and the "sea". But Mr Weerakoon has trouble with the overhead projector. Although Vasantha is not a "computer man", he thinks he can help. He explains that the human body has a "magnetism", and that machines "respond to their touch". It works, and Mr Weerakoon suggests the taxi driver stay to get a few tips on marketing.

As Vasantha listens to Mr Weerakoon discuss "stuff about bell curves and market segmentation", he decides it all seems over-complicated "hot air". He remembers how simple it was to set up his small transport business once he retired at 55.

At lunchtime Mr Weerakoon invites Vasantha for lunch on the "terrace". There, Vasantha strikes up a conversation with a man who used to fight in the **Sri Lankan civil war**. The man, Lucky, tells Vasantha about his new venture using disused naval ships to take tourists whale-watching and gambling. When he starts to talk about politics, Vasantha excuses himself to get dessert. Mr Weerakoon stops him: he has lost his phone, a "Brand-new Nokia". Vasantha is certain it is in the taxi, so he goes to look for it.

He finds the phone but, before he takes it back, he opens it with a pin number he says most people use. He decides to go on the terrace to close his eyes. There he contemplates the way the sea air can make one forget their troubles. He wants to tell Mr Weerakoon that marketing is easy, but the most important thing to know is how to deal with a small mistake, such as not having a secure phone. The ambiguous ending implies that "common sense" and peace of mind is the best way to achieve success.





Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).



Your notes

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Fluke

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Romesh Gunsekera's *Fluke*.

What are the key themes in *Fluke*?

Theme	Analysis
Individual identity	▪ Contrasting characters emphasise key differences between the lifestyles of Vasantha and the people he meets: ▪ Mr Weerakoon is a "modern" entrepreneur who is "flustered" and preoccupied with his laptop and phone ▪ Vasantha has a modest but successful business with no need for marketing or complex technology ▪ He does "what I love" ▪ Gunsekera implies modern versions of success create emotional turmoil and complications: ▪ Mr Weerakoon is reckless with important information and becomes distressed at every small hurdle ▪ The man, Lucky, who "might have been a naval commander", is "troubled" after his involvement in the war
The natural world	▪ The story contrasts an over-complicated modern life with a traditional, peaceful life watching the "sea" "under the trees" ▪ Vasantha thinks about the whales and how separated they are from human plans, and he refers to Japanese whaling: ▪ The title of the story has a double meaning: it can refer to luck, and the shape of whales' fins ▪ Gunsekera raises modern concerns about the natural world:



Your notes

	▪ Vasantha's passengers worry about climate change and tell him their "eco-preferences" ▪ Gunesequera highlights changes in Sri Lanka through contrasts between nature and the built environment: ▪ Through the conference centre window you could "just about glimpse the sea" ▪ There is a meeting room full of "hot air" and a "terrace" with a "soothing" sea breeze
Reality and illusion	▪ The story presents the illusion of confidence through Mr Weerakoom who speaks "loudly" and is "bursting with energy" ▪ But Guneskera reveals how insecure and foolish he is: ▪ He loses his "Brand-new" phone which he says is a "Big, big disaster" and he cannot fix the projector ▪ He carries a "pretend leather" briefcase ▪ In contrast, Vasantha is a small business owner who is insightful and unassuming: ▪ He cares nothing for "rank" ▪ Ironically, Vasantha ends the story with the upper hand

Writer's methods in Fluke

How does Gunesequera present his ideas and perspectives?

In the short story Fluke by Romesh Gunesequera, the thoughts of an elderly taxi driver reflect the changing nature of a war-torn Sri Lanka, and the meaning of success in a modern world.

Technique	Analysis
First-person narrator	▪ Using a first-person narrator, Gunesequera presents the perspective of an elderly taxi driver to show alternative attitudes to modern life: ▪ Vasantha is humble and polite to his passengers ▪ But his monologue reveals strong opinions: ▪ He does not "give a toss about social standing or net worth" ▪ He is also witty: ▪ He describes Lucky as "the navy's latest secret weapon for commercial supremacy" "settled on a lounge"



Your notes

	■ Guneskera is able to raise themes about tradition and modernity by showing the thoughts of a retired man, Vasantha: ■ He sees himself as disconnected from the “brand-new face of our remodelled country”
Symbolism	■ To explore themes about the natural world, Gunesequera uses natural imagery to symbolise peace: ■ Outside, the sea breeze is “making music with the trees” ■ Sibilance draws attention to nature as timeless and slow-paced: ■ The “sea keep[s] the same soft time” ■ Vasantha lets the sea air help him to “sleep like old people whose memories have finally receded and left them in peace” ■ This is juxtaposed with the modern, technological world where the men are “half-throttled by their plump polyester ties”: ■ The laptop case symbolises the constancy of work in a modern world and represents Mr Weerakoon’s reliance on technology ■ Mr Weerakoon repeatedly “patted the bag as if it were a pet” ■ Phones are “nursing secrets, aching to spill the beans”: the personification presents them as threatening ■ Gunesequera contrasts a humble life with the desire for wealth with the use of traditional and modern symbols: ■ Vasantha uses his “good chi” to solve technological issues, which implies a spiritual nature can make life easier ■ In response, Mr Weerakoon refers to expensive brands when he asks Vasantha to get his “Gucci” flowing



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners recommend you form a personal and evaluative response in answer to the question. They suggest you use your introductory paragraph to introduce an argument or thesis statement that presents your own interpretation of the writer’s ideas and perspectives.

It is best not to simply provide biographical and historical information about the writer in your introduction paragraph. Instead, use this to showcase your interpretation of the story. For example, you could write, “Gunesequera sets his short story Fluke in war-torn Sri Lanka to present an elderly man’s perspective on a changing world”.

Fluke key quotations



Your notes

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to use your knowledge of the story in the question to inform your interpretation. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to remember direct quotations, though. Summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referring to plot events are all considered valid evidence.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Romesh Gunsekera's *Fluke*, arranged by the following themes:

- **Individual identity**
- **The natural world**
- **Reality and illusion**

Individual identity



"I do whatever my customer wants me to do. That's the key. It is no big secret" — Vasantha

Meaning and context

- Vasantha, the taxi driver, has a simple approach to his business
- He says he does what he is told by his customers

Analysis

- Vasantha's blunt, short sentences present him as a practical man with a set of fundamental values about how to live his life and run his business
- He is presented as independent and self-assured



"Whatever your foibles, your wanton misdeeds, you can dream of new ventures and be a success if you can sleep easy. It can't be that difficult" — Vasantha

Meaning and context

- When Vasantha is closing his eyes on the terrace, he thinks about his many problems and reflects on people's weaknesses and mistakes
- Vasantha considers the idea of worry, stress, and, perhaps, guilt



- He decides that if you can “sleep easy” there is always hope for the future and a chance for new plans

Analysis

- Implicitly, Gunesekera shows how Vasantha faces a moral dilemma:
 - He has seen Mr Weerakoon’s “secrets” on his phone and reflects on whether he should make use of this information, offer him advice, or do nothing
- Vasantha reflects on human nature and concludes that peace of mind is the best way to achieve real success

The natural world



“Someone once told me that the human body has magnetism in it, and with some people the flow is such that machines respond to their touch” — Vasantha

Meaning and context

- When Mr Weerakoon has problems with the projector, Vasantha helps him
- He says that humans have the power to use magnetic energy on machines

Analysis

- Gunesekera highlights ideas about spirituality and individual success
- He refers to energy throughout his story:
 - At first it is the bustling energy of Mr Weerakoon
 - This is later shown to be nervous energy
- Vasantha’s “good **chi**” refers to the flow of energy that connects humans to all other things, a magnetic energy that brings peace and good fortune



“I wondered what the whales out there in their sea lanes knew of us and our schemes” — Vasantha

Meaning and context

- When Vasantha sits outside to reflect, he thinks about the whales
- He has just heard that Lucky plans to use naval ships to take tourists whale watching, and he wonders if the whales know

Analysis



- Gunesekera's narrator is witty:
 - His **wry** comment highlights the lack of involvement of whales, and, thus, the natural world, in human plans
- The word "schemes" suggests the plans are devious, and, perhaps, exploitative

Reality and illusion



"Like he is bursting with energy, which I imagine impresses his clients who are in need of gurus with vitality" — Narrator

Meaning and context

- Vasantha, the narrator, describes his passenger, Mr Weerakoon, as someone full of "energy" and life
- He thinks this is sure to make him appear like he knows what he is talking about:
 - He thus appears like a "guru", a Hindu spiritual leader

Analysis

- Gunesekera creates a humorous take on modern life by showing Vasantha's cynical perspective on a modern world:
 - The entrepreneur, Mr Weerakoon, is compared to someone exploding with restlessness
- The narrator mocks him using a religious reference to "gurus", and implies that his show of confidence does not translate to real expertise



"These days it is so hard to spot a fake" — Vasantha

Meaning and context

- When Vasantha sees a "bird" in the conference centre, he has to check to make sure it is a statue, not a real bird
- He thinks so many things are "fake" copies in the modern world

Analysis

- Gunesekera's short sentence presents a resigned and disappointed narrator
- He implies that the modern world is made up of illusions, and that something genuine is hard to find

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.



Your notes